Optimization Strategies for Plasmonic-Enhanced Thin-Film Solar Cells

Mir Masrur
Rajshahi University of Engineering & Technology
Rajshahi, Bangladesh
mir.masrur0008@gmail.com

***Abstract*—Plasmonic solar cells are an emerging class of photovoltaics that incorporate metal nanoparticles to improve light absorption and carrier generation. This review highlights recent advancements in optimizing thin-film solar cells, especially CdTe and silicon-based structures, using plasmonic nanostructures. The methodology, key achievements, research gaps, and future directions have been examined based on various literature sources. This paper focuses on how different nanoparticle materials, shapes, and configurations influence solar cell performance and what steps can be taken to overcome current limitations.**

***Keywords*—Plasmonic nanoparticles, CdTe solar cells, FDTD simulation, nanostructure optimization, efficiency enhancement.**

I. Introduction

In recent years, plasmonic-enhanced solar cells have attracted significant attention due to their ability to manipulate light at the nanoscale, enabling higher absorption and efficiency in thin-film solar cells. These enhancements are achieved using metallic nanoparticles like silver (Ag), gold (Au), or combinations thereof. With the help of numerical tools like FDTD and CHARGE solvers, researchers simulate the interactions between light and nanostructures to optimize solar cell designs.

This report reviews how different configurations and materials of plasmonic nanoparticles have been implemented, evaluated, and proposed to improve solar cell performance. The focus includes CdTe, Si, SnS, and perovskite-based solar cells, with an emphasis on performance improvements, challenges, and gaps in the current research landscape.

II. Literature Review

A. Optimization of CdTe TFSC Using Spherical Nanoparticles [1]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
All the data presented in this paper were generated using the commercially available FDTD and CHARGE simulation software.	Silver (Ag) spherical nanoparticles offer the most effective enhancement in the performance of CdTe thin-film solar cell.	Here only use spherical NPs. Non-spherical NPs or hybrid NPs can be tested for better output. .

B. Use of HfN and ZrN as Plasmonic Mirrors [2]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
Developed epitaxial thin films of hafnium nitride (HfN) and zirconium nitride (ZrN).	Achieved ~90.3% solar reflectivity and ~95% infrared reflectivity in HfN and ZrN thin films.	Its very expensive to use HfN and ZrN

C. Enhancing CdS/SnS Cells with Au and Ag NPs [3]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
Plasmonic silver (Ag) and gold (Au) nanoparticles (~7.1 ± 1.4 nm for Au and ~10.01 ± 2.2 nm for Ag) were spin-coated on the surface of thermally evaporated CdS/SnS heterojunction solar cells.	Optical absorption at 550 nm increased by 235.9% (Au-NPs) and 835.6% (Ag-NPs) compared to uncoated cells. .	Even with enhancement, the efficiency (~4.3%) remains relatively low compared to other solar cell technologies (like CdTe or silicon).

D. Shape Effect of Ag NPs in CuPc Films [4]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
FDTD method, also called the Yee algorithm, have been chased of reported results.	It was found that cylindrical Ag-NPs resulted in higher absorption enhancement and short circuit current compared to other shapes	The research focuses on Copper phthalocyanine as the organic semiconductor material. The effectiveness of different shapes of silver nanoparticles might vary with other semiconductor materials.

E. Bow-Tie Nanostructures for Si TFSC [5]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
The researchers employed the Finite-Difference Time-Domain (FDTD) Solution solver for optical enhancement analysis and the CHARGE .	Hybrid bow-tie plasmonic nanostructures can significantly enhance the opto-electronic efficiency of thin-film solar cells compared to spherical nanoparticles alone.	Future work is planned to focus on designing triangular nanoparticles with scattering resonances that match the plasmon resonance of the spherical silver nanoparticle to further maximize optical and electrical enhancements .

F. CdTe TFSC with 200nm Ag NPs [6]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
The methodology employed in this paper involved computational study utilizing Finite-Difference Time-Domain (FDTD) solutions and CHARGE software from Ansys-Lumerical, Inc.	The study found that using 200 nm Ag NPs resulted in a 13.47% increase in efficiency for CdTe TFSCs	Faces challenges such as the availability of Tellurium and low light absorption near the band gap

G. Plasmonic Perovskite Cells [7]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
Theoretical analysis and finite element method (FEM) simulations to calculate the enhancement of the interface plasmon effect and photo-generation profiles	Ag particles with a radius of 80nm, can achieve an average absorption efficiency of 80%, which is a 24% improvement compared to a pure CaTiO3 thin-film layer structure	The thermal instability of perovskite layers on ZnO surfaces, which has slowed progress in the field

H. Monomer vs Dimer NPs in Si Cells [8]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
Optical simulations using ANSYS Lumerical to measure electron-hole pair generation, followed by electrical simulations to determine electrical parameters and efficiency	A basic silicon thin-film solar cell with a 2µm absorber layer initially showed an efficiency of 8.62%	Though this paper gets a good efficiency but it is comperatively low as compared to traditional solar cells with 25%.

I. Effect of NP Defects in Arrays [9]

Methodology	Achievement	Research Gap
Finite Difference Time Domain (FDTD) simulations to model structural defects in homogeneous metal nanoparticle arrays on silicon-based thin-film solar cells (TFSCs)	larger silver nanoparticles could improve cell performance, while missing nanoparticles or the inclusion of silica impurities generally reduced it	Future work could explore a wider range of defect types and investigate engineering techniques to control light scattering for improved performance

III. Existing Solution

This section outlines the techniques and strategies currently used to improve plasmonic solar cell performance

A. FDTD and CHARGE solvers

These are widely used simulation tools for optical and electrical modeling of nanostructured solar cells. They allow detailed analysis of light-matter interaction and carrier behavior within solar cells, enabling precise optimization.

B. Material selection

While Ag and Au provide excellent plasmonic performance, they are expensive. Alternatives like HfN and ZrN offer similar optical benefits, especially in the UV range, but come with higher fabrication complexity and cost.

C. Shape optimization

Non-spherical geometries such as cylindrical, triangular, and bow-tie shapes can focus light more efficiently due to localized surface plasmon resonances.

These shapes outperform spherical nanoparticles in enhancing optical absorption.

IV. FUTURE WORK

A. Use of non-spherical and hybrid nanoparticles

Future studies should explore more diverse geometries and combinations to tune plasmonic resonance across broader spectral ranges. Shapes like nanorods, stars, and core-shell structures could offer higher field enhancement.

B. Advanced multilayer and tandem architectures

Employing stacked layers with different bandgaps or incorporating plasmonic layers into tandem cells can maximize light harvesting across the solar spectrum.

C. Cost-effective fabrication

Low-cost, scalable synthesis techniques for integrating nanoparticles into solar cells must be developed. Printing, roll-to-roll, and laser-based deposition methods can support commercialization.

D.Artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning (ML)

These can be used to automate the design and optimization of nanoparticle configurations, predicting performance outcomes and suggesting efficient layouts based on large simulation datasets.

V. CONCLUSION

Plasmonic nanostructures show great promise in enhancing the efficiency of thin-film and ultrathin solar cells. Despite impressive progress, challenges such as thermal stability, material scarcity, and fabrication complexity remain. Continued innovation in nanoparticle design, material integration, and simulation methodologies is crucial to make plasmonic solar cells viable for commercial use.

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